SYSTEMIC DEPTHS

Designing & Architecting Emergent Traditional Roguelikes

A Comprehensive Practitioner's Guide

Rule Composition, Spatial Topologies, Cellular Dynamics, & Autonomous AI in Python

Google DeepMind Agentic Engineering

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Table of Contents

Preface: The Systemic Turn

Traditional roguelikes occupy a unique position in software engineering and game design. While mainstream game development often prioritizes high-fidelity linear rendering pipelines, hand-scripted set pieces, and rigid animation state trees, traditional roguelikes (*NetHack*, *Caves of Qud*, *Brogue*, *Cogmind*, *ADOM*, *Tales of Maj'Eyal*, *Dwarf Fortress*) thrive on a radically different paradigm: **systemic simulation and emergent gameplay**.

In a systemic game, the designer does not write scripts that dictate what happens when the player encounters a specific puzzle or boss. Instead, the designer specifies:

1. **Physical & Chemical Rules**: Properties of matter, propagation of energy, and transformation of state (combustion, conduction, freezing, evaporation, gravity).
2. **Affordances & Verbs**: Generalized actions that apply uniformly across actors, items, and environment (**`Burn`**, **`Freeze`**, **`Electrify`**, **`Dip`**, **`Throw`**, **`Shatter`**, **`Quaff`**).
3. **Autonomous Agents**: Entities with perception, utility functions, and goals who interact with the exact same simulation rules as the player.

When these orthogonal systems interact, stories happen that neither the designer nor the programmer explicitly scripted:

- An iron potion bottle thrown at a charging minotaur shatters, splashing lamp oil across the floor;
- A goblin shaman casts a spark, unintentionally igniting the oil slick;
- The resulting blaze superheats an adjacent shallow puddle, boiling it into a dense bank of blinding steam;
- Blinded, the minotaur stumbles blindly into a chasm, collapsing a rickety wooden bridge and cutting off goblin reinforcements.

This book is an architectural and mathematical exploration of how to build games where this kind of emergence is not a glitch, but the core engine of player agency.

Who This Book Is For

This book is written for **competent software engineers, systems architects, and technical game designers**.

We assume:

- You are comfortable with modern programming paradigms (object composition, functional pipelines, event-driven architectures, graph algorithms, and data modeling).
- You understand basic asymptotic analysis (`O(1)`, `O(V + E)`, `O(N \log N)`) and discrete mathematics (matrices, sets, graphs).
- You want deep, production-grade architectural guidance rather than high-level platitudes or beginner tutorials on "how to write a game loop".

All code examples in this book are written in **modern Python (3.12+)**, emphasizing type hints (**`typing`**), immutable data structures (**`dataclasses(slots=True)`**), protocols, and decoupled event dispatchers. Python is chosen because its expressive syntax serves as executable pseudo-code that can be translated cleanly into C++, Rust, C#, or Go.

What Makes This Book Different

Most roguelike tutorials guide you through building a minimal clone of *Rogue* (1980): a tile map, `@` moving with arrow keys, bumping into **`g`** for 5 damage, and descending a staircase.

While valuable for novices, such architectures hit a hard wall when you attempt to add rich interactions:

- If you implement burning by adding **`is_burning`** to your **`Monster`** class, what happens when an item in a wooden chest catches fire?
- If a shock spell hardcodes damage to monsters in a radius, how does it naturally conduct through a puddles of water across three rooms?
- If your event bus triggers immediate side effects recursively, how do you prevent call stack overflow when two reactive entities trigger each other?

This book addresses these fundamental architectural challenges head-on.

How to Read This Book

The book is organized into six interconnected parts:

1. **Part I: Philosophy, Foundations & Architecture of Emergence** (Chapters 1–2): Deconstructs emergence and establishes decoupled event, entity, and scheduling architectures.
2. **Part II: The Reactive World - Space, Materials & Physics** (Chapters 3–5): Implements layered 2D grids, symmetric shadowcasting vision, double-buffered cellular automata, and the affordance matrix.
3. **Part III: Entities, Items, Status & Magic** (Chapters 6–8): Models modular body topologies, reactive modifier stacks, fluid alchemy, and spatial spell geometry.
4. **Part IV: Intelligence, Perception & Ecology** (Chapters 9–10): Builds tactical Dijkstra maps, utility AI that exploits environmental hazards, and inter-faction ecosystems.
5. **Part V: Procedural Generation for Systemic Play** (Chapters 11–12): Generates tactical dungeon topologies designed to provoke emergent decisions rather than static corridor crawls.
6. **Part VI: Architecture, Balance, Testing & Production** (Chapters 13–15): Covers deterministic simulation, headless Monte Carlo balance testing, save serialization, and a walkthrough of the companion engine.

Every chapter is accompanied by tested, runnable code in the companion **`pyrogue_emergent`** engine. Let us begin.

Chapter 1: The Anatomy of Emergence in Roguelikes

> *"Emergence is what happens when an author designs the rules of a world rather than the story that takes place within it."*

1.1 The Berlin Interpretation Revisited

In 2008, the International Roguelike Development Conference formulated the **Berlin Interpretation**, outlining high-value factors that historically defined the genre:

- Grid-based discrete spatial movement
- Turn-based discrete time simulation
- Procedural generation of environments and items
- Permadeath (consequential mortality)
- Non-modal interaction (all actions—movement, inventory, combat, magic—occur within the same overarching game interface)

While these rules were formulated as descriptive history, they contain a profound, hidden software architectural virtue: **they establish a discrete, deterministic laboratory for combinatorial systems**.

MERMAID

```
graph LR
subgraph Discrete Constraints
Grid[Discrete Spatial Grid]
Turn[Discrete Time Ticks]
NonModal[Non-Modal Global Rules]
end

subgraph Systemic Emergence
Rules[Orthogonal Rule Engine]
Interactions[Combinatorial Interactions]
end

Grid --> Rules
Turn --> Rules
NonModal --> Rules
Rules --> Interactions
```

Continuous 3D physics engines (e.g. Havok, PhysX) must fight floating-point drift, tunneling, numerical instability, and clipping errors. In contrast, a discrete grid and a turn-based tick scheduler provide a mathematical sandbox where state transitions are discrete, exact, and fully traceable.

1.2 First-Order vs. Second-Order Design

To architect emergence, we must understand the fundamental difference between **First-Order** and **Second-Order** game design.

First-Order Design (Explicit Scripting)

In first-order design, the developer explicitly scripts behaviors and outcomes for specific pairs of entities:

```python
# Anti-pattern: Combinatorial spaghetti of hardcoded interactions
def on_player_use_item_on_monster(player, item, monster):
if item.name == "wand_of_fire" and monster.name == "mummy":
monster.take_damage(50) # Mummies are vulnerable to fire
elif item.name == "potion_of_water" and monster.name == "fire_elemental":
monster.take_damage(30)
elif item.name == "potion_of_acid" and monster.has_shield:
monster.shield.corrode()
```

If a game has N items and M monsters, a complete first-order interaction matrix requires $O(N \times M)$ handwritten branches. As the codebase grows, adding a single new item or monster requires touching dozens of unrelated files.

Second-Order Design (Rule & Property Composition)

In second-order design, entities do not know about each other. Instead, entities possess **properties** and **materials**, and actions manipulate **universal physical laws**:

```python
# Idiomatic Emergence: Decoupled property propagation
def apply_thermal_energy(target_entity, heat_joules: float):
material = target_entity.get_component(Material)
current_temp = target_entity.get_component(Temperature)

current_temp.celsius += heat_joules / material.thermal_mass

if current_temp.celsius >= material.ignition_point:
target_entity.add_component(Combustion(rate=10))
```

In this paradigm:

- A **`Mummy`** takes double fire damage simply because its material is **`DryLinen(flammability=0.9)`**.
- A **`WoodenDoor`**, a **`ScrollOfIdentify`**, and a **`PoolOfOil`** all burn according to the exact same thermodynamic rules.
- You do not write $O(N \times M)$ scripts. You write $O(N + M)$ components and a handful of universal systemic laws ($O(K)$), creating an interaction space that scales exponentially with zero additional code.

1.3 Case Studies in Roguelike Emergence

NetHack: The Dev Team Thinks of Everything

NetHack is legendary for its seemingly infinite depth. However, much of *NetHack*'s emergence is a hybrid: hundreds of bespoke, idiosyncratic edge-cases hand-crafted over decades (e.g. dipping an uncursed amethyst into a potion of booze to identify real vs fake gems). While enchanting, this approach is notoriously difficult to maintain.

Caves of Qud: Deep Systemic Simulation

Caves of Qud embraces true second-order emergence. Temperature is a continuous simulation: freezing temperatures turn liquid pools into solid blocks of ice, which can be melted with thermal rays, producing puddles that conduct electrical discharges from mutant abilities. Body parts are distinct entities: an axe can sever an arm, which drops as an item on the floor, which can then be picked up and wielded as a bludgeon or cooked into a meal.

Brogue: Ecological Elegance

Brogue demonstrates that systemic emergence does not require endless complexity. By restricting the environment to a focused set of reactive materials—gas (steam, poison, confusion), fluids (water, deep water, swamp gas, brimstone), and terrain (grass, foliage, webs)—*Brogue* creates intricate tactical puzzles. Igniting dry grass creates a firestorm that consumes oxygen and expands into a choking smoke cloud, forcing both player and monsters to flee into deep water.

1.4 The Hazards of Emergence

Emergence is not an unalloyed good. Unconstrained combinatorial interactions introduce severe design hazards:

1. Chaos Without Agency (The "YASD" Problem)

"Yet Another Stupid Death" is a classic roguelike trope. However, if a player dies from an opaque chain reaction occurring off-screen without telegraphing or opportunity for counterplay, emergence ceases to feel clever and becomes deeply frustrating.

> ***Design Principle**: Emergent cascades must be legible. Every state change must produce perceptual cues (visual glyphs, acoustic sound events, combat log causality traces).*

2. Runaway Positive Feedback Loops

Consider a fire system where fire generates heat, heat causes an explosion, and the explosion creates more fire over a larger radius. Without negative feedback (fuel consumption, oxygen depletion, thermal dissipation), a single spark can permanently destroy the entire dungeon level in an infinite loop.

MERMAID

```
graph TD
Fire[Active Fire] -->|Increases| Heat[Ambient Heat]
Heat -->|Exceeds Threshold| Explosion[Explosion Event]
Explosion -->|Spawns| Fire
style Explosion stroke:#ff0000,stroke-width:2px;
```

3. Infinite Recursion and Call Stack Exhaustion

When Entity A reacts to Entity B, which reacts back to Entity A, naive event architectures crash with a **`RecursionError`**. As we will build in Chapter 2, a robust simulation requires **phased event dispatching** and **hard recursion depth bounding**.

Chapter 2: Architectural Patterns for Interconnected Systems

"The fatal flaw of classic object-oriented inheritance in game development is assuming entities have fixed, essential natures rather than dynamic, transient capabilities."

2.1 The Failure of Classical Inheritance

Consider a traditional object-oriented hierarchy for an RPG:

CODE

```
GameObject
■■■ Item
■ ■■■ Weapon
■ ■■■ Potion
■■■ Actor
■■■ Player
■■■ Monster
```

Now introduce emergent gameplay requirements:

1. A **Potion of Lamp Oil** can be quaffed (like an Item), thrown as a projectile (like a Weapon), splashed on the floor to form a flammable surface (like Terrain), or frozen into a solid block (like an Obstacle).
2. A **Monster** who is polymorphed into a wooden chest can be picked up, put into an inventory, opened, or chopped down for firewood.
3. An **Iron Sword** wielded in an electrical storm acts as a lightning rod, transferring current through the wielder's arm into a water puddle.

In classical single or multiple inheritance, accommodating these combinations leads to the **Diamond Inheritance Problem**, massive God-classes with hundreds of dormant boolean flags (**`is_flammable`**, **`is_throwable`**, **`is_equippable`**, **`is_liquid`**), or fragile subclass explosions.

2.2 Entity-Component-System (ECS) Architecture

To allow arbitrary combinations of behaviors, we separate identity, data, and behavior:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Entity ID
E1["Entity #42 (Potion of Oil)"]
end

subgraph Pure Data Components
C1[Position: Vec2(4, 5)]
C2[Physics: weight=0.5, fragile=True]
C3[LiquidContainer: oil, vol=50]
C4[Flammable: fuel=25]
end

subgraph Systems / Pipelines
S1[MovementSystem]
S2[CellularSystem]
S3[AffordancePipeline]
end

E1 --> C1
E1 --> C2
E1 --> C3
E1 --> C4

C1 -.-> S1
C2 & C3 -.-> S3
C4 -.-> S2
```

- **Entity**: A lightweight integer identifier (e.g. **`entity_id = 42`**).
- **Component**: A pure data container with no game logic (**`dataclass`**).
- **System / Pipeline**: Stateless functions that query entities possessing specific sets of components and mutate simulation state.

High-Performance Python Component Storage

In Python 3.12, component storage can be implemented cleanly with typed dictionaries:

PYTHON

```
from dataclasses import dataclass
from typing import TypeVar, Type, Any

T = TypeVar("T")

class EntityManager:
def __init__(self) -> None:
self._next_id: int = 1
self._components: dict[Type[Any], dict[int, Any]] = {}

def add_component(self, entity_id: int, component: Any) -> None:
comp_type = type(component)
if comp_type not in self._components:
self._components[comp_type] = {}
self._components[comp_type][entity_id] = component

def get_component(self, entity_id: int, comp_type: Type[T]) -> T | None:
return self._components.get(comp_type, {}).get(entity_id)
```

2.3 The Phased Multi-Stage Event Pipeline

When multiple reactive systems interact, a single event (e.g., *Player strikes Barrel with Flaming Torch*) must trigger multiple evaluation phases without causing race conditions or infinite call loops.

We structure our interaction pipeline into **5 explicit phases**:

MERMAID

```
sequenceDiagram
participant Caller
participant Bus as EventBus
participant Validator as Phase 1: VALIDATE
participant Intention as Phase 2: INTENTION
participant Executor as Phase 3: EXECUTE
participant Reactor as Phase 4: REACTION
participant Cascade as Phase 5: CASCADE (Queue)

Caller->>Bus: dispatch_full_pipeline(event)
Bus->>Validator: Can action occur? (e.g. immunity, silence)
Validator-->>Bus: Approved / Cancelled
Bus->>Intention: Pre-strike triggers (e.g. reactive shields)
Bus->>Executor: Mutate state (apply damage, ignite tile)
Bus->>Reactor: Immediate consequences (flash, sound)
Bus->>Cascade: Queue secondary events (shattered glass, fire spread)
Bus-->>Caller: Result
```

1. `Phase.VALIDATE`

Handlers determine whether the action is legally allowed to proceed. Any handler can cancel the event or alter its parameters (e.g. target is in a temporal stasis field, preventing damage).

2. `Phase.INTENTION`

The action is validated and about to occur. Handlers can prepare the world state or trigger defensive reactions (e.g. a magical mirror reflects a spell beam before it lands).

3. `Phase.EXECUTE`

The canonical mutation takes place: HP is deducted, fuel is consumed, coordinates are updated.

4. `Phase.REACTION`

Immediate synchronous feedback occurs: visual animations are flagged, acoustic noise is generated for AI listening systems.

5. `Phase.CASCADE`

Consequential events are enqueued into a FIFO buffer rather than executed recursively. The event bus then drains this queue sequentially, with each child event incrementing its **`depth`**.

2.4 Guarding Against Recursion Cascades

To prevent catastrophic infinite loops (such as two conductive entities endlessly shocking each other), every event records its cascade depth. If **`depth > MAX_CASCADE_DEPTH`**, the event is automatically aborted:

```python
def dispatch_phase(self, event: Event, phase: Phase) -> bool:
if event.depth > self.max_cascade_depth:
event.cancel(f"Max cascade depth ({self.max_cascade_depth}) exceeded")
return False

for handler in self._handlers[type(event)][phase]:
if event.cancelled and phase != Phase.VALIDATE:
break
handler(event, phase)

return not event.cancelled
```

2.5 Time Scheduling: Energy-Based Tick Queues

Traditional roguelikes must support actors with varying movement and action speeds (e.g., a hasty rogue moving twice per round, or a heavy golem moving once every two rounds).

Rather than dividing turns into coarse rounds, we utilize an **Energy / Tick Accumulator Queue** using a priority min-heap:

$$\text{Next Ready Tick} = \text{Current Tick} + \left\lfloor \frac{\text{Standard Energy Cost} \times 1000}{\text{Actor Speed}} \right\rfloor$$

```python
import heapq
from dataclasses import dataclass, field

STANDARD_ENERGY_COST = 1000

@dataclass(order=True)
class ScheduledActor:
ready_tick: int
actor_id: int = field(compare=False)
speed: int = field(default=1000, compare=False)

class EnergyScheduler:
def __init__(self) -> None:
self.current_tick: int = 0
self._heap: list[ScheduledActor] = []

def next_actor(self) -> int | None:
if not self._heap:
return None
actor = heapq.heappop(self._heap)
self.current_tick = actor.ready_tick
return actor.actor_id

def complete_turn(self, actor: ScheduledActor, cost_mult: float = 1.0) -> None:
cost = int(STANDARD_ENERGY_COST * cost_mult)
delay = max(1, (cost * 1000) // actor.speed)
actor.ready_tick = self.current_tick + delay
heapq.heappush(self._heap, actor)
```

With our foundational architecture established, we can now construct the reactive spatial world in Part II.

Chapter 3: Spatial Models, Layered Topologies & Vision

"Space in a roguelike is not merely a geometric coordinate system; it is a dense medium through which physical forces, sensory information, and chemical reactions propagate."

3.1 Discrete Distance Metrics and Tactical Topology

Traditional roguelikes exist on discrete grids. The choice of distance metric fundamentally dictates tactical combat and geometry:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Distance Metrics
Chebyshev["Chebyshev Distance (L_inf)<br/>max(|dx|, |dy|)<br/>8-way King moves. Diagonals cost 1.0."]
Manhattan["Manhattan Distance (L_1)<br/>|dx| + |dy|<br/>4-way Orthogonal moves."]
Euclidean["Euclidean Distance (L_2)<br/>sqrt(dx^2 + dy^2)<br/>True circular radii for spells and
FOV."]
end
```

The Metric Mismatch Problem

In Chebyshev distance (standard 8-way movement), diagonals cost the same movement time as cardinal steps. As a result, a "circle" of radius R is geometrically an axis-aligned square:

$$\text{Area}_{\text{Chebyshev}}(R) = (2R + 1)^2$$

If spell blast radii are calculated using Chebyshev distance, fireballs become expanding squares. If calculated using Euclidean distance, circular spells on a Chebyshev movement grid introduce tactical corner-cutting opportunities.

Our reference engine uses **Chebyshev distance** for actor movement adjacency and **Euclidean distance** for sensory perception and explosive blast radii to ensure natural circular decay.

3.2 The Layered Grid Architecture

In a rich systemic simulation, a single (x, y) coordinate can simultaneously contain:

1. **Terrain**: A stone floor (**`TileType.FLOOR`**)
2. **Surface / Fluid**: A 2-inch pool of lamp oil (**`FluidType.OIL, volume=40`**)
3. **Atmosphere / Gas**: A dense bank of toxic smoke (**`GasType.SMOKE, density=65`**)
4. **Items**: A pile of wooden arrows and a gold ring
5. **Actor**: A goblin scout standing in the oil

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Coordinate Tile at (x, y)
ActorLayer[Actor Layer: Goblin Scout #104]
ItemLayer["Item Layer: [Arrows #201, Ring #202]"]
GasLayer["Gas Layer: Toxic Smoke (density=65)"]
FluidLayer["Fluid Layer: Lamp Oil (volume=40)"]
TerrainLayer[Terrain Layer: Stone Floor]
end

ActorLayer --> ItemLayer
ItemLayer --> GasLayer
GasLayer --> FluidLayer
FluidLayer --> TerrainLayer
```

Stashing these directly in an unstructured array leads to overwriting bugs (e.g. dropping a potion deletes the floor tile).

We encapsulate each coordinate as a discrete **`CellState`**:

PYTHON

```python
@dataclass(slots=True)
class CellState:
tile: TileType = TileType.FLOOR
fluid_type: FluidType = FluidType.NONE
fluid_volume: int = 0
gas_type: GasType = GasType.NONE
gas_density: int = 0
temperature: int = 20
fire_intensity: int = 0
fire_fuel: int = 0
items: list[int] = field(default_factory=list)
actor: int | None = None

@property
def blocks_vision(self) -> bool:
if self.tile in (TileType.WALL, TileType.DOOR_CLOSED):
return True
# Dense smoke or opaque gas obscures vision
return self.gas_type == GasType.SMOKE and self.gas_density > 60
```

3.3 Symmetric Shadowcasting

Field of View (FOV) determines what the player and autonomous agents can see.

The Asymmetry Bug in Naive Raycasting

Naive line-of-sight (casting Bresenham rays to every perimeter tile) creates jagged artifacts and severe **asymmetry**: a monster standing behind a corner pillar can see the player, but the player cannot see the monster.

The Shadowcasting Principle

Symmetric Shadowcasting operates by dividing the 2D grid around an observer into 8 octants. Within each octant, the algorithm sweeps outward row by row from slope *`-1.0`* to *`1.0`*, projecting shadows when encountering opaque obstacles.

CODE

```
\ Octant 1 /
\ /
Octant \ Row 3 / Octant
7 \ Row 2 / 0
\ Row 1/
\ @ /
```

When a transparent tile is adjacent to an opaque tile in the same row, the algorithm calculates the exact angular slope boundary and recursively splits the view frustum into narrower sub-cones:

$$\text{Slope}_{\text{start}} = \frac{\text{col} - 0.5}{\text{row} + 0.5}, \quad \text{Slope}_{\text{end}} = \frac{\text{col} - 0.5}{\text{row} - 0.5}$$

PYTHON

```
def _scan_octant(
octant: int, origin: Vec2, radius: int, row: int,
start_slope: float, end_slope: float,
is_blocking: Callable[[Vec2], bool], visible: set[Vec2]
) -> None:
if start_slope >= end_slope or row > radius:
return

first_col = int(math.floor(row * start_slope + 0.5))
last_col = int(math.ceil(row * end_slope - 0.5))
prev_blocked = False

for col in range(first_col, last_col + 1):
dx, dy = transform_octant(row, col, octant)
pos = Vec2(origin.x + dx, origin.y + dy)

if origin.euclidean_dist(pos) <= radius:
visible.add(pos)

blocked = is_blocking(pos)
if prev_blocked:
if not blocked:
prev_blocked = False
start_slope = (col - 0.5) / (row + 0.5)
else:
if blocked:
prev_blocked = True
new_end = (col - 0.5) / (row - 0.5)
_scan_octant(octant, origin, radius, row + 1, start_slope, new_end, is_blocking, visible)

if not prev_blocked:
_scan_octant(octant, origin, radius, row + 1, start_slope, end_slope, is_blocking, visible)
```

This guarantees **mathematical symmetry**: $\text{Visible}(A, B) \iff \text{Visible}(B, A)$.

3.4 Multi-Sensory Propagation

Vision is only one perceptual channel. In systemic roguelikes, perception extends to:

1. **Infravision / Thermal Emission**: Hot entities (burning torches, fire elementals, lava) emit thermal signatures that bypass smoke banks.
2. **Tremorsense**: Heavy moving entities transmit vibrations through contiguous stone floor tiles.

3. **Acoustic Wavefronts**: Combat actions and explosions produce sound events that travel along open corridors, fading with distance and wall penetration.

With our spatial and sensory layers established, Chapter 4 examines the physical and cellular mechanics that animate this world.

Chapter 4: Material Systems & Cellular Automata

"Do not code a fire spell that hurts trolls. Code a fire system that releases thermal energy into matter, and make trolls out of flammable wood."

4.1 Materials as First-Class Citizens

In many traditional games, an object's behavior is dictated by its high-level type (**`Weapon`**, **`Consumable`**, **`Door`**). In a systemic roguelike, an object's behavior is derived from its **constituent material properties**:

MERMAID

```
classDiagram
class Material {
+MaterialType type
+float conductivity
+float flammability
+float hardness
+int melting_point
+int boiling_point
+float thermal_mass
}
class Entity {
+int id
+Material material
+Physics physics
}
Entity o-- Material
```

Material	Conductivity (*0.0-1.0*)	Flammability (*0.0-1.0*)	Hardness	Melting Pt (*^\circ\text{C}*)
Wood	*0.05*	*0.80*	*2.0*	Combusts @ *250^\circ\text{C}*
Iron	*0.95*	*0.00*	*8.0*	*1538^\circ\text{C}*
Flesh	*0.40*	*0.20*	*1.0*	Cooks @ *70^\circ\text{C}*
Glass	*0.00*	*0.00*	*0.5* (Fragile)	*1400^\circ\text{C}*
Water	*0.85* (Fluid)	*0.00*	*0.0*	Boils @ *100^\circ\text{C}*
Oil	*0.10* (Fluid)	*0.95*	*0.0*	Flashpoint @ *120^\circ\text{C}*

When an entity is struck by a fire spell, electric shock, or blunt force, the interaction resolver queries its **`Material`** component. A wooden door burns, an iron shield conducts electricity, and a glass potion shatters.

4.2 Cellular Automata for Environmental Simulation

Cellular Automata (CA) allow complex spatial simulations—such as fire spread, fluid pooling, and gas diffusion—to emerge from simple, localized neighborhood transition rules.

The Double-Buffering Invariant

A critical error in naive CA implementation is modifying the grid in place during iteration:

PYTHON

```
# Anti-pattern: In-place mutation causes directional skew
for y in range(height):
for x in range(width):
if grid[y][x].is_burning:
grid[y+1][x].is_burning = True # Burns instantly downward in 1 frame!
```

To maintain physical consistency, all updates must read from the **Current Buffer** (*T*) and write exclusively into the **Next Buffer** (*T + 1*), committing the new state in a single atomic step:

PYTHON

```
def step(self) -> list[str]:
# Read from self.grid, write into next_cells
next_cells = [copy.deepcopy(cell) for cell in self.grid._cells]

# 1. Evaluate Fire, Thermodynamics, and Phase Changes
# 2. Evaluate Gas Diffusion
# 3. Evaluate Fluid Leveling

# Commit next_cells back to grid in-place
```

4.3 Fire, Combustion, and Thermodynamics

Fire is modeled as an active combustion state with temperature, fuel, and smoke output:

MERMAID

```
stateDiagram-v2
[*] --> Unignited
Unignited --> Combustion : Temp > Ignition Threshold OR Spark applied
Combustion --> Combustion : Fuel > 0 (Consumes fuel, adds heat, emits smoke)
Combustion --> Extinguished : Fuel == 0 OR Water applied
Combustion --> FlashExplosion : Vapor density > 10
Extinguished --> [*]
```

Transition Equations

For any cell *(x, y)* in state *T*:

1. **Heat Production**:

$$T_{\text{next}} = T_{\text{curr}} + I_{\text{fire}} \times 5$$

2. **Fuel Consumption**:

$$\text{Fuel}_{\text{next}} = \max(0, \text{Fuel}_{\text{curr}} - 1)$$

3. **Neighbor Ignition**:

$$\forall n \in \text{Neighbors}_8(x, y): \text{If } \text{Flammable}(n) \land I_{\text{fire}}(x,y) > 0 \implies I_{\text{fire}}(n) \leftarrow \text{Ignite}$$

```python
if curr.fire_intensity > 0:
nxt.temperature = min(1000, curr.temperature + curr.fire_intensity * 5)
nxt.fire_fuel = max(0, curr.fire_fuel - 1)

# Emit smoke into the atmosphere
if nxt.gas_type in (GasType.NONE, GasType.SMOKE):
nxt.gas_type = GasType.SMOKE
nxt.gas_density = min(100, nxt.gas_density + 15)

# Spread to adjacent flammable fluids (oil, alcohol)
for neighbor in pos.neighbors_8():
n_curr = self.grid.get_cell(neighbor)
n_next = get_next(neighbor)
if n_curr.fluid_type in (FluidType.OIL, FluidType.ALCOHOL) and n_next.fire_intensity == 0:
n_next.fire_intensity = 80
n_next.fire_fuel = n_curr.fluid_volume // 2 + 5
n_next.temperature = max(n_next.temperature, 250)
```

4.4 Gas Diffusion and Pressure Equalization

Gases (smoke, poison gas, steam) expand outward to occupy open adjacent space while dissipating over time:

$$\text{Diffusion Amount} = \left\lfloor \frac{\text{Density}(x, y)}{|\text{Open Neighbors}| + 2} \right\rfloor$$

```python
for pos in self.grid.iter_positions():
curr = self.grid.get_cell(pos)
if curr.gas_density <= 0 or curr.gas_type == GasType.NONE:
continue

nxt = get_next(pos)
nxt.gas_density = max(0, nxt.gas_density - 2) # Ambient dissipation

open_neighbors = [n for n in pos.neighbors_4() if self.grid.get_cell(n).tile != TileType.WALL]
if open_neighbors and curr.gas_density > 10:
flow = curr.gas_density // (len(open_neighbors) + 2)
for n_pos in open_neighbors:
n_next = get_next(n_pos)
if n_next.gas_type == GasType.NONE:
n_next.gas_type = curr.gas_type
n_next.gas_density = min(100, n_next.gas_density + flow)
```

4.5 Thermodynamic Phase Transitions

A hallmark of deep emergent simulation is matter changing physical states based on local temperature:

MERMAID

```
graph LR
Ice["Ice (Solid Tile)"] -->|Heat > 0°C| Water["Water (Fluid)"]
Water -->|Cold < 0°C| Ice
Water -->|Heat > 100°C| Steam["Steam (Gas Cloud)"]
Steam -->|Dissipates| Air["Clear Atmosphere"]
```

PYTHON

```
# Water boils to Steam
if curr.fluid_type == FluidType.WATER and curr.temperature > 100:
nxt.fluid_volume = max(0, curr.fluid_volume - 20)
if nxt.fluid_volume == 0:
nxt.fluid_type = FluidType.NONE
nxt.gas_type = GasType.STEAM
nxt.gas_density = min(100, nxt.gas_density + 30)

# Water freezes to Solid Ice
if curr.fluid_type == FluidType.WATER and curr.temperature < 0:
nxt.tile = TileType.ICE
nxt.fluid_type = FluidType.NONE
nxt.fluid_volume = 0
```

By decoupling these physical equations into self-contained cellular rules, the world behaves like an interactive ecosystem where fire, smoke, water, and ice respond dynamically to player tactics.

Chapter 5: Verbs, Affordances & The Interaction Matrix

> *"An affordance is not a property of an object alone, nor is it a property of an actor alone. It is a relationship of possibility between them." — Adapted from James J. Gibson, The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception*

5.1 Affordance Theory in Game Design

In traditional game engines, an action is often tightly bound to a specific actor-target pair:

PYTHON

```python
# The brittle approach: Nouns dictate verbs
class Player:
def drink_potion(self, potion: HealingPotion): ...
def unlock_door(self, door: WoodenDoor, key: BrassKey): ...
def strike_goblin(self, goblin: Goblin, sword: IronSword): ...
```

This design fails the moment a player attempts to:

- Throw a healing potion at an undead skeleton to harm it with positive energy;
- Dip an arrow into a potion of poison;
- Kick a locked door to shatter its brittle hinges;
- Quaff lamp oil when covered in acid to coat their stomach lining.

Under **Affordance-Driven Architecture**, verbs query **component affordances** rather than concrete classes:

MERMAID

```mermaid
graph TD
Verb[Global Verb: THROW] --> TargetQuery{Target Query}
TargetQuery -->|Has Physics.fragile?| ShatterPipeline[Shatter & Spill Payload]
TargetQuery -->|Has CombatStats?| KineticDamage[Apply Blunt Kinetic Force]
TargetQuery -->|Has LiquidContainer?| ReleaseFluid[Disperse Fluid into Tile]
TargetQuery -->|Standard Item?| DropOnTile[Place on Floor]
```

5.2 The Universal Verb Matrix

Our reference engine defines an extensible suite of foundational verbs:

Verb	Required Component / Affordance	Systemic Outcome
`Ignite`	**`Flammable`** OR **`Fluid(OIL/ALCOHOL)`**	Raises local temp, initiates combustion, ignites adjacent vapors.
`Electrify`	**`Conductive`** OR **`Fluid(WATER/ACID)`**	Flood-fills contiguous conductive cells, shocks all occupants.
`Freeze`	**`Fluid(WATER)`** OR **`Status(WET)`**	Solidifies water into ice tiles; immobilizes and brittles actors.

`Throw`	**`Physics`**	Traces Bresenham trajectory; delivers kinetic impact & shatters fragile items.
`Shatter`	**`Physics(fragile=True)`**	Destroys container, spills contained fluids/gases onto landing tile.
`Dip`	**`LiquidContainer`** + Any Item	Coats item in target fluid (e.g. arrow dipped in oil or poison).

5.3 Case Study: A 5-Link Emergent Cascade

Let us trace what happens under the hood when a player performs the following sequence:

1. **Player dips an wooden arrow into a vial of oil.**
- **`DipAction`** attaches an **`Oiled`** status modifier to the arrow entity.
2. **Player touches the oiled arrow to a wall torch.**
- **`IgniteAction`** sets **`Flammable.is_burning = True`** on the arrow.
3. **Player shoots the flaming arrow through a corridor filled with Flammable Vapor.**
- As the projectile passes through each tile, the **`CombustionSystem`** detects **`GasType.FLAMMABLE_VAPOR`**.
- The gas flashes into a raging fireball, creating a pressure wave that blows open a closed wooden door.
4. **The flaming arrow strikes an Explosive Red Barrel standing in a shallow puddle of water.**
- **`ThrowAction`** deals kinetic damage, shattering the barrel.
- **`AffordanceSystem`** triggers **`Physics.explosive`**, dealing 40 radial damage.
5. **The thermal wave superheats the water puddle.**
- The water instantly vaporizes into a dense cloud of blinding **`Steam`**.
- Two goblin archers on the other side of the room lose line of sight due to the steam cloud and fire randomly into the smoke.

MERMAID

```
sequenceDiagram
participant Player
participant Arrow as Arrow Entity
participant Vapor as Flammable Vapor Tile
participant Barrel as Explosive Barrel
participant Water as Water Puddle
participant Goblin as Goblin Archer

Player->>Arrow: Dip in Oil & Ignite
Arrow->>Vapor: Projectile passes through tile
Note over Vapor: Vapor ignites into Fireball!
Arrow->>Barrel: Kinetic Impact
Note over Barrel: Barrel explodes (40 Radial Damage)!
Barrel->>Water: 400°C Heat Wave
Note over Water: Water boils into dense Steam cloud!
Water->>Goblin: Steam blocks Line-of-Sight
Note over Goblin: Goblin blinded; loses target lock!
```

Because every link in this chain was evaluated through decoupled event dispatches and cellular properties, no developer ever wrote a function named **`shoot_flaming_arrow_through_gas_to_blow_up_barrel_and_steam_blind_goblins()`**.

The behavior **emerged** entirely from orthogonal rules.

Chapter 6: Dynamic Entity Composition & Reactive Status Effects

> *"A creature is not a static monolith of statistics; it is a modular biological system capable of mutation, dismemberment, and compounding chemical states."*

6.1 Modular Body Topologies

In conventional RPGs, equipment slots are hardcoded into an interface: **`Head`**, **`Torso`**, **`MainHand`**, **`OffHand`**, **`Boots`**.

In an emergent roguelike (in the lineage of *Caves of Qud* and *Dwarf Fortress*), bodies are dynamic graphs of **limbs and organs**:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
Torso[Torso] --> Head[Head]
Torso --> LeftArm[Left Arm]
Torso --> RightArm[Right Arm]
Torso --> LeftLeg[Left Leg]
Torso --> RightLeg[Right Leg]

Head --> Eyes["Eyes (Vision Channel)"]
LeftArm --> LeftHand["Left Hand (Grasp Slot)"]
RightArm --> RightHand["Right Hand (Grasp Slot)"]
```

When an actor undergoes dynamic mutations or injuries:

- **Severing an Arm**: Drops the arm as a physical meat item on the floor, destroys the attached hand equipment slot, and drops whatever weapon was wielded.
- **Growing Extra Limbs**: A chimera mutation adds two additional **`Arm`** nodes, instantly expanding the actor's grasp slots and allowing quadruple-wielding.

6.2 Status Effects as Reactive Modifier Stacks

A status effect is not merely a timer that inflicts damage; it is a **reactive state modifier** that alters how the entity interacts with all future events.

Stacking and Modifier Pipelines

When an entity's attribute (e.g. movement speed, defense, thermal conductivity) is queried, it passes through the active modifier stack:

$$\text{Effective Speed} = (\text{Base Speed} + \sum \text{Flat Modifiers}) \times \prod \text{Multipliers}$$

PYTHON

```
@dataclass
class ActiveStatus:
status_type: StatusType
duration: int
intensity: int = 1

@dataclass
class StatusContainer:
statuses: dict[StatusType, ActiveStatus] = field(default_factory=dict)
```

6.3 Compounding Status Interactions

Emergent status design means statuses **react with each other** upon application, forming a chemical state transition graph:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
Wet[Status: WET]
Burning[Status: BURNING]
Oiled[Status: OILED]
Shocked[Status: SHOCKED]

Wet -->|Combines with Burning| Extinguish["Extinguish Fire + Cloud of Steam"]
Oiled -->|Combines with Burning| Inferno["Escalate to INFERNO (Double Damage + Spread)"]
Wet -->|Combines with Shocked| Stunned["Surge into STUNNED (Loss of Action)"]
Wet -->|Combines with Freezing| Frozen["Solidify into FROZEN (Fragile to Blunt Impact)"]
```

Implementing Compounding Rules in Python

PYTHON

```
def apply_status(self, entity_id: int, status_type: StatusType, duration: int, intensity: int = 1) ->
list[str]:
container = self.ecs.get_component(entity_id, StatusContainer)
existing = container.statuses

# 1. Wet + Burning -> Extinguish and emit Steam
if status_type == StatusType.WET and StatusType.BURNING in existing:
del existing[StatusType.BURNING]
self._emit_steam_at(entity_id)
return [f"Entity {entity_id}'s flames were extinguished in a cloud of steam!"]

# 2. Oiled + Burning -> Inferno
if status_type == StatusType.BURNING and StatusType.OILED in existing:
del existing[StatusType.OILED]
intensity *= 2
duration += 3
existing[StatusType.BURNING] = ActiveStatus(StatusType.BURNING, duration, intensity)
return [f"The oil on Entity {entity_id} ignited into an inferno!"]

# 3. Wet + Shocked -> Stunned
if status_type == StatusType.SHOCKED and StatusType.WET in existing:
existing[StatusType.STUNNED] = ActiveStatus(StatusType.STUNNED, duration=2, intensity=1)
return [f"Electric current surged through the water on Entity {entity_id}, stunning them!"]

existing[status_type] = ActiveStatus(status_type, duration, intensity)
return [f"Entity {entity_id} is now {status_type.name.lower()}."]
```

6.4 Guarding Against Status Infinite Recursion

Consider a circular status trap:

- Status A applies Status B.
- Status B applies Status A.

Without defensive architecture, this triggers an immediate **`RecursionError`**. We protect the simulation through two invariants:

1. **Atomic Application**: A status application cannot trigger synchronous event re-entry on the same entity during the same call stack frame.
2. **Decoupled Tick Resolution**: Ongoing periodic damage (e.g. poison ticks, burning ticks) is evaluated strictly during the entity's scheduled turn in the **`EnergyScheduler`**, preventing cascading tick storms within a single time slice.

Chapter 7: Emergent Item Systems, Alchemy & Deduction

"An unidentified potion is not merely a randomized loot drop; it is a chemical reagent and an information puzzle waiting to be solved."

7.1 Items as First-Class Physical Actors

In traditional roguelikes, items are not inert inventory strings. They possess physical properties that participate in the world simulation even when lying on the ground or stored inside containers:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Physical Properties of Items
Weight["Weight & Volume: Determines encumbrance and throwing force"]
Buoyancy["Buoyancy: Wood floats; iron sinks to deep water bed"]
Degradation["Degradation: Acid corrodes metal; moisture rots scrolls"]
Combustibility["Combustibility: Fire burns wooden chests and paper"]
Containment["Containment: Bottles shatter; flasks insulate liquids"]
end
```

The Container Cascade

When an iron chest containing three spell scrolls and a potion of water is exposed to dragon fire:

1. The chest's iron material resists combustion (**`flammability = 0.0`**).
2. However, heat conducts through the iron (**`conductivity = 0.95`**), raising the chest's internal cavity temperature to *`350^\circ\text{C}`*.
3. The glass potion bottle reaches its boiling point, violently bursting from thermal steam pressure.
4. The released water evaporates into steam, soaking and extinguishing the burning scrolls inside before they turn to ash.

7.2 Chemical Alchemy and Fluid Mixing

Rather than hardcoding static crafting recipes (**`Item A + Item B = Item C`**), an emergent alchemy system models **thermodynamic fluid reactions**:

MERMAID

```
graph LR
Acid["Acid Pool"] + Water["Water Pool"] --> Dilute["Exothermic Dilution<br/>(Produces Acrid Steam + Heat)"]
Alcohol["Alcohol Flask"] + Acid["Acid Pool"] --> Toxic["Chemical Synthesis<br/>(Billowing Poison Gas Cloud)"]
Oil["Oil Slick"] + Water["Water Pool"] --> Layer["Immiscible Multi-Layer Pool"]
```

PYTHON

```
@dataclass(frozen=True)
class ReactionResult:
resulting_fluid: FluidType
resulting_volume: int
resulting_gas: GasType = GasType.NONE
gas_amount: int = 0
temperature_delta: int = 0
message: str = ""

class AlchemySystem:
@staticmethod
def mix_fluids(fluid_a: FluidType, vol_a: int, fluid_b: FluidType, vol_b: int) -> ReactionResult:
pair = {fluid_a, fluid_b}

# Acid + Water: Exothermic dilution
if pair == {FluidType.ACID, FluidType.WATER}:
return ReactionResult(
resulting_fluid=FluidType.WATER,
resulting_volume=vol_a + vol_b,
resulting_gas=GasType.STEAM,
gas_amount=20,
temperature_delta=40,
message="Acid violently hissed as it was diluted by water, sending up acrid steam!"
)

# Alcohol + Acid: Volatile toxic gas synthesis
if pair == {FluidType.ALCOHOL, FluidType.ACID}:
return ReactionResult(
resulting_fluid=FluidType.NONE,
resulting_volume=0,
resulting_gas=GasType.POISON_GAS,
gas_amount=60,
temperature_delta=60,
message="Alcohol and acid synthesized violently into a billowing toxic vapor cloud!"
)

# Oil + Water: Immiscible
if pair == {FluidType.OIL, FluidType.WATER}:
dominant = FluidType.OIL if vol_a >= vol_b else FluidType.WATER
return ReactionResult(dominant, vol_a + vol_b, message="Oil floats atop the water.")

return ReactionResult(fluid_a, vol_a + vol_b)
```

7.3 Identification as Deductive Reasoning

A core pleasure of traditional roguelikes (*NetHack*, *Brogue*, *Caves of Qud*) is **deductive identification under incomplete information**.

The Three Tiers of Information

CODE

```
[Unidentified] --> "A smoky magenta potion"
[Partially Known] --> "This potion is flammable and tastes like petroleum"
[Fully Identified] --> "Potion of Lamp Oil"
```

Contextual Identification Affordances

Instead of forcing players to hoard expensive "Scrolls of Identify", systemic design invites players to test items through environmental interaction:

- **The Fire Test**: Throwing an unidentified potion into a burning campfire. If it extinguishes the flame, it is *Water*; if it explodes into a blaze, it is *Oil* or *Alcohol*; if it turns the flame green, it is *Acid*.
- **The Price ID Puzzle**: Merchants buy items based on true value. A player observing a shopkeeper offering 150 gold for a ruby ring can deduce it is a *Ring of Teleportation Control* rather than a *Ring of Warning*.
- **The Monster Test**: Throwing an unidentified wand at a monster. If the monster turns invisible, it is a *Wand of Invisibility*; if the monster bounces backward, it is a *Wand of Force*.

This transforms inventory management from a bookkeeping chore into an active scientific experiment.

Chapter 8: Magic, Projectiles & Spatial Mechanics

"A spell should not merely apply damage in a radius; it should displace mass, reflect off reflective surfaces, and fundamentally alter the local topology."

8.1 Spatial Spell Geometries

Spells in an emergent roguelike are spatial mathematical functions mapped across discrete coordinates:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Spell Geometries
Ray["Ray / Beam: Bresenham line with reflection angle"]
Cone["Cone / Frustum: Angular wedge expanding with distance"]
Burst["Radial Burst: Euclidean circle applying kinetic shockwave"]
Chain["Chain Arc: Minimum spanning tree across conductive entities"]
Vortex["Vortex: Inward radial force vector pulling entities"]
end
```

Specular Beam Reflection

When a magical ray (such as a *Lightning Bolt* or *Laser Beam*) strikes a solid wall, instead of terminating, it can reflect specularly across the normal vector:

PYTHON

```
def reflect_vector(direction: Vec2, wall_normal: Vec2) -> Vec2:
# On discrete square grids, hitting a vertical wall inverts dx; horizontal inverts dy
return Vec2(
-direction.x if wall_normal.x != 0 else direction.x,
-direction.y if wall_normal.y != 0 else direction.y,
)
```

In tight dungeon corridors, a single lightning bolt can ricochet three or four times, carving through an entire advancing goblin column before striking the caster who miscalculated the bounce angle (a quintessential *NetHack* tactical lesson).

8.2 Projectile Physics and Kinetic Transfer

When a physical item (an iron javelin, a boulder, or a potion flask) is launched, it carries **kinetic momentum**:

$$E_k = \frac{1}{2} m v^2$$

MERMAID

```
graph LR
Throw[Thrown Object] --> Trajectory[Bresenham Raycast]
Trajectory --> Collision{Obstacle Encountered?}
Collision -->|Actor| Impact[Transfer Momentum: Knockback + Damage]
Collision -->|Wall| BounceOrShatter{Fragility Check}
BounceOrShatter -->|Fragile| Shatter[Shatter & Disperse Contents]
BounceOrShatter -->|Sturdy| Drop[Drop into Cell]
```

Momentum-Driven Knockback

If kinetic energy exceeds the target actor's stability threshold:

1. The actor is shoved K tiles backward along the impact vector.
2. If the actor collides with a solid wall during knockback, they suffer **blunt impact damage** proportional to remaining momentum.
3. If the actor is shoved into an open chasm, they fall, triggering vertical transition mechanics.

8.3 Blast Dynamics and Structural Destruction

Explosions are modeled as two coupled phenomena:

1. **Thermal Radiance**: Instantaneous spike in temperature ($+400^\circ\text{C}$), igniting flammable tiles and vaporizing standing fluids.
2. **Kinetic Shockwave**: Radial force expanding outward from the epicenter, destroying fragile structures:

PYTHON

```
def apply_explosion(epicenter: Vec2, radius: int, peak_force: int, grid: LayeredGrid, ecs:
EntityManager):
for dy in range(-radius, radius + 1):
for dx in range(-radius, radius + 1):
target = Vec2(epicenter.x + dx, epicenter.y + dy)
if not grid.in_bounds(target):
continue

dist = epicenter.euclidean_dist(target)
if dist > radius:
continue

# Attenuation with distance
force = int(peak_force * (1.0 - dist / (radius + 1)))
cell = grid.get_cell(target)

# Structural destruction
if cell.tile == TileType.DOOR_CLOSED or cell.tile == TileType.DOOR_OPEN:
cell.tile = TileType.FLOOR
# Spawn wooden splinters item

# Thermal flash
cell.temperature += force * 10
cell.fire_intensity = max(cell.fire_intensity, force)
```

8.4 Reality-Warping Mechanics

Systemic engines shine brightest when handling non-Euclidean magical phenomena:

1. Telefragging (Spatial Occlusion Resolution)

When an actor teleports onto a coordinate occupied by another actor:

- If both are solid, the teleported actor's mass shears through the occupying entity, causing catastrophic damage proportional to relative mass.
- If teleporting into solid stone, the actor is crushed or shifted to the nearest open topological manifold.

2. Polymorph Chains

Polymorphing an entity alters its **`Material`**, **`Renderable`**, and **`CombatStats`** while preserving its identity, tags, and inventory. Polymorphing an angry dragon into a mouse retains its inventory; polymorphing a water puddle into a gelatinous cube absorbs all items resting on the tile into the cube's gelatinous body.

Chapter 9: The Living Dungeon: AI & Ecosystems

> *"If monsters only exist to run directly at the player and deal damage, the dungeon is not an ecosystem; it is a queue of numbers waiting to be decremented."*

9.1 The Failure of Simple Aggro

In naive roguelikes, enemy AI consists of a single loop: $\text{If player visible } \implies \text{Step towards player } \implies \text{Attack}$

This produces flat, repetitive gameplay where monsters blindly march through blazing fire, step into pools of bubbling acid, and ignore weapons lying on the ground.

In an emergent roguelike, creatures:

1. **Perceive Hazards**: Value their own survival and avoid dangerous surfaces.
2. **Exploit the Environment**: Kick braziers, shatter oil potions under the player, and seek chokepoints.
3. **Participate in Ecology**: Hunt prey, scavenge corpses, fight rival factions, and flee when wounded.

9.2 Tactical Dijkstra Maps

While A^* is excellent for single-source to single-destination pathfinding, it is computationally expensive to run independently for dozens of monsters every turn.

Dijkstra Maps (popularized by Brian Walker in *Brogue*) solve multi-agent navigation, hazard avoidance, and tactical retreats simultaneously using a single distance field computation.

MERMAID

```
graph TD
GoalNodes["Goal Nodes (e.g. Player, Health Font)"] --> DijkstraField[Dijkstra Map Computation]
TerrainCost[Terrain Movement Cost + Hazard Penalties] --> DijkstraField

DijkstraField --> Downhill["Step Downhill: Hunt Goal / Path Around Hazards"]
DijkstraField --> Uphill["Step Uphill: Flee from Danger / Tactical Retreat"]
DijkstraField --> Gradient["Iso-Contours: Flank & Surround Target"]
```

Hazard Cost Weighting

To teach monsters to respect environmental hazards, we inject dynamic cost penalties into the Dijkstra calculation:

$$\text{Step Cost}(n) = \text{Base Cost}(n) + \text{Hazard Penalty}(n)$$

PYTHON

```
class DijkstraMap:
def compute(self, goals: Iterable[Vec2], hazard_cost_fn: Callable[[Vec2], int] | None = None) -> None:
self._values = [self.INFINITY] * (self.width * self.height)
heap: list[tuple[int, int, int]] = []

for goal in goals:
if self.grid.in_bounds(goal):
idx = self._index(goal)
self._values[idx] = 0
heapq.heappush(heap, (0, goal.x, goal.y))

while heap:
cost, x, y = heapq.heappop(heap)
curr = Vec2(x, y)

if cost > self._values[self._index(curr)]:
continue

for neighbor in curr.neighbors_8():
if not self.grid.in_bounds(neighbor):
continue

cell = self.grid.get_cell(neighbor)
if cell.tile in (TileType.WALL, TileType.DOOR_CLOSED):
continue

base_step = 14 if (neighbor.x != x and neighbor.y != y) else 10
hazard_penalty = 0
if hazard_cost_fn:
hazard_penalty = hazard_cost_fn(neighbor)
else:
if cell.fire_intensity > 0:
hazard_penalty += 200 # High penalty for fire
if cell.fluid_type == FluidType.ACID:
hazard_penalty += 150 # High penalty for acid

new_cost = cost + base_step + hazard_penalty
n_idx = self._index(neighbor)

if new_cost < self._values[n_idx]:
self._values[n_idx] = new_cost
heapq.heappush(heap, (new_cost, neighbor.x, neighbor.y))
```

- **Hunting**: Stepping **downhill** leads the monster directly to the player via the safest available path around fire and acid.
- **Fleeing**: Stepping **uphill** guides a wounded creature away from the player into uncharted rooms.

9.3 Utility AI for Environmental Exploitation

To enable creatures to make creative tactical choices, we implement a **Utility AI System**. Instead of rigid decision trees, every possible action receives a continuous utility score between `0.0` and `10.0`:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
ActorState[Actor State & Surroundings] --> EvalFlee[Score: Flee / Retreat]
ActorState --> EvalHazard[Score: Ignite Oil Under Target]
ActorState --> EvalThrow[Score: Throw Fragile Potion]
ActorState --> EvalMelee[Score: Standard Melee Attack]

EvalFlee --> Winner["Winner Selection: Max(Utility Scores)"]
EvalHazard --> Winner
EvalThrow --> Winner
EvalMelee --> Winner
```

PYTHON

```
class UtilityAI:
def evaluate_best_action(self, actor_id: int, enemy_id: int | None) -> UtilityAction:
actor_pos = self.ecs.get_component(actor_id, Position)
actor_stats = self.ecs.get_component(actor_id, CombatStats)
best_action = UtilityAction("wait", utility_score=1.0)

# 1. Self-preservation curve (Sigmoid / Inverse Ratio)
hp_ratio = actor_stats.hp / max(1, actor_stats.max_hp)
if hp_ratio < 0.25 and enemy_id:
flee_score = (1.0 - hp_ratio) * 10.0
if flee_score > best_action.utility_score:
best_action = UtilityAction("flee", target_id=enemy_id, utility_score=flee_score)

# 2. Environmental affordance: Ignite oil under enemy
if enemy_id:
enemy_pos = self.ecs.get_component(enemy_id, Position)
if enemy_pos:
enemy_cell = self.grid.get_cell(enemy_pos.pos)
if enemy_cell.fluid_type == FluidType.OIL and enemy_cell.fire_intensity == 0:
# High utility to trigger oil explosion under the enemy!
oil_score = 8.5
if oil_score > best_action.utility_score:
best_action = UtilityAction("ignite_hazard", target_pos=enemy_pos.pos, utility_score=oil_score)

# 3. Direct Melee Attack
if enemy_id and actor_pos.pos.chebyshev_dist(enemy_pos.pos) == 1:
melee_score = 6.0
if melee_score > best_action.utility_score:
best_action = UtilityAction("attack", target_id=enemy_id, utility_score=melee_score)

return best_action
```

9.4 Ecological Faction Systems and Infighting

Dungeons feel alive when creatures have autonomous agendas beyond attacking the player:

MERMAID

```
graph LR
Wolves[Wild Wolves] -->|Prey On| Goblins[Goblin Tribe]
Goblins -->|Hostile To| Player[Player Character]
Wolves -->|Hostile To| Player
Undead[Skeleton Army] -->|Attacks All Living| Wolves
Undead -->|Attacks All Living| Goblins
Undead -->|Attacks All Living| Player
```

PYTHON

```
class FactionSystem:
_DEFAULT_RELATIONS = {
("goblin", "player"): Disposition.HOSTILE,
("wolf", "player"): Disposition.HOSTILE,
("wolf", "goblin"): Disposition.PREY, # Wolves hunt goblins
("goblin", "wolf"): Disposition.HOSTILE, # Goblins fight off wolves
("undead", "player"): Disposition.HOSTILE,
("undead", "goblin"): Disposition.HOSTILE, # Undead kill everything living
("undead", "wolf"): Disposition.HOSTILE,
}
```

When a player lures a pack of wild wolves into a goblin barricade, the player can step back, watch the battle unfold, and finish off the wounded survivors.

Chapter 10: Information, Perception & Player Agency

"When a player dies from an emergent chain reaction they understood and anticipated, they laugh and restart. When they die from an invisible cascade they could not see, they uninstall."

10.1 The Principle of Legible Complexity

Emergence is thrilling because of **unforeseen combinations of known rules**. However, if the player does not possess accurate information about the world state, emergence collapses into feeling like arbitrary cruelty.

MERMAID

```
graph TD
RuleClarity[1. Transparent Rules] --> Legibility[Legible Emergence]
VisualCues[2. Sensory & Visual Feedback] --> Legibility
Telegraphing[3. Pre-Action Telegraphing] --> Legibility
CausalityLogs[4. Explicit Causality Logging] --> Legibility

Legibility --> PlayerAgency[Player Agency & Mastery]
```

To preserve player agency in complex systemic environments:

1. **Never hide physical laws**: If oil is flammable, all oil in the world must burn consistently.
2. **Telegraph large cascades**: High-impact explosions and environmental collapses should give the player at least 1 turn of warning (e.g. *"The ceiling groans under severe structural strain..."*).
3. **Log causality, not just damage**: Do not output **`"You take 45 damage."`** Output: **`"The barrel exploded, detonating the oil slick, engulfing you in flames for 45 damage!"`**

10.2 Asymmetric Perception and Monster Memory

Entities in the game world do not share a global omniscience map. Each autonomous agent possesses its own **Perceptual Profile** and **Spatial Memory**:

MERMAID

```
stateDiagram-v2
[*] --> Unaware : Wandering / Foraging
Unaware --> Suspicious : Hears noise / Smells scent trail
Suspicious --> Alert : Spots player / Takes damage
Alert --> Searching : Target breaks Line-of-Sight
Searching --> Unaware : Search timer expires
```

PYTHON

```
@dataclass
class AgentMemory:
last_known_target_pos: Vec2 | None = None
turns_since_spotted: int = 0
alert_state: str = "unaware" # unaware, suspicious, alert, searching
investigation_target: Vec2 | None = None
```

When a player breaks line-of-sight around a corner and steps into a side alcove:

1. The chasing goblin continues running toward **`last_known_target_pos`** (the corner tile).
2. Arriving at the corner, the goblin finds the player missing and transitions to **`searching`** mode, sweeping adjacent corridors.
3. This creates tactical affordances for **stealth, ambushes, and distraction** (such as throwing a rock down an opposite hallway to produce an acoustic alert).

10.3 Acoustic Wavefronts and Scent Trails

Acoustic Propagation

Every significant action produces an acoustic wavefront with a volume rating (in decibels / radius):

PYTHON

```
def emit_sound(origin: Vec2, volume: int, grid: LayeredGrid, ecs: EntityManager):
# Propagate sound through open tiles with attenuation
dmap = DijkstraMap(grid)
dmap.compute([origin])

for entity, (pos, sensory, memory) in ecs.query(Position, SensoryProfile, AgentMemory):
dist = dmap.get(pos.pos)
if dist <= volume and sensory.has_hearing:
memory.alert_state = "suspicious"
memory.investigation_target = origin
```

Action	Acoustic Radius (Tiles)
Creeping / Sneaking	*1*
Standard Movement	*3*
Melee Combat	*6*
Shattering Potion Bottle	*8*
Explosion / Structural Collapse	*25* (Full Level Alert)

10.4 Causality Tracking in Post-Mortem Logs

When an event triggers cascades, tracking **`parent_id`** on every event allows reconstructing the exact causal graph of any death or victory:

CODE

```
[DEATH RECONSTRUCTION - TURN 412]
■■ Player threw Potion of Lamp Oil at (12, 8)
■ ■■ Potion shattered on stone wall -> Spilled 50 units of Oil
■■ Goblin Shaman cast Spark at (12, 8)
■ ■■ Spark ignited Oil -> Firestorm initiated
■ ■■ Firestorm superheated Water Puddle -> Produced 40 density Steam
■ ■■ Firestorm detonated Explosive Barrel at (13, 8)
■ ■■ Radial Explosion (40 Damage) -> Struck Player (HP: 28 -> -12) [FATAL]
```

This degree of causality logging transforms defeats into memorable, hilarious, and intellectually satisfying learning experiences.

Chapter 11: Level Generation with Tactical Affordances

"A procedural dungeon should not be a maze of empty rectangular rooms; it should be an obstacle course of tactical affordances and environmental pressure cookers."

11.1 Designing Topologies for Emergence

Procedural generation (ProcGen) in traditional roguelikes is often taught as generating rooms and hallways via Binary Space Partitioning (BSP) or Random Walks.

However, flat rectangular rooms connected by straight corridors produce monotonous combat: players back up into a 1-tile corridor, press the attack key repeatedly to funnel monsters, and repeat.

To foster emergent play, levels must feature **topological friction**:

- **Chokepoints & Flanking Loops**: Cyclic graphs that allow both player and AI to flank or retreat.
- **Elevation & Chasm Barriers**: Obstacles that can be bypassed using kinetic throwing, teleportation, or bridge construction.
- **Hazard Basins**: Low-lying depressions where heavy gases (poison, smoke) settle and liquids pool.

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Tactical Dungeon Topology
Rooms[Cyclic Room Graph] --> Caverns[Organic Cellular Caves]
Caverns --> Hazards[Hazard Distribution]
Hazards --> Vents[Gas Vents & Basins]
Hazards --> Slicks[Oil Slicks & Flammable Foliage]
Hazards --> Waterways[Conductive Waterways & Bridges]
end
```

11.2 Cellular Automata Cave Generation (The 4-5 Rule)

For organic, natural subterranean caverns, the **4-5 Cellular Automata** algorithm produces winding caverns with natural alcoves and varying corridor widths:

PYTHON

```
class CellularCaveGenerator:
@staticmethod
def generate(grid: LayeredGrid, fill_prob: float = 0.45, iterations: int = 4, rng: random.Random |
None = None) -> None:
rand = rng or random.Random()
w, h = grid.width, grid.height

# 1. Initialize with uniform random noise
for y in range(h):
for x in range(w):
pos = Vec2(x, y)
if x == 0 or x == w - 1 or y == 0 or y == h - 1:
grid.set_tile(pos, TileType.WALL)
elif rand.random() < fill_prob:
grid.set_tile(pos, TileType.WALL)
else:
grid.set_tile(pos, TileType.FLOOR)

# 2. Smooth via 4-5 rule
for _ in range(iterations):
new_tiles: dict[Vec2, TileType] = {}
for y in range(1, h - 1):
for x in range(1, w - 1):
pos = Vec2(x, y)
wall_count = sum(1 for n in pos.neighbors_8() if grid.get_cell(n).tile == TileType.WALL)
new_tiles[pos] = TileType.WALL if wall_count >= 5 else TileType.FLOOR

for p, tile in new_tiles.items():
grid.set_tile(p, tile)
```

11.3 Procedural Placement of Tactical Features

Once the geometric foundation is carved, we populate the map with **tactical features**:

MERMAID

```
graph LR
Floors[Floor Coordinates] --> Cluster[Cluster Sampling]
Cluster --> Oil[Oil Puddle Clusters]
Cluster --> Water[Water Basin Clusters]
Cluster --> Barrels[Explosive Barrels near Chokepoints]
```

PYTHON

```
class TacticalFeaturePlacer:
@staticmethod
def populate(grid: LayeredGrid, ecs: EntityManager, rng: random.Random | None = None) -> None:
rand = rng or random.Random()
floor_positions = [
p for p in grid.iter_positions()
if grid.get_cell(p).tile == TileType.FLOOR and grid.get_cell(p).actor is None
]
rand.shuffle(floor_positions)

# 1. Spawn Oil Pools
for center in floor_positions[:3]:
for n in [center] + center.neighbors_4():
if grid.in_bounds(n) and grid.get_cell(n).tile == TileType.FLOOR:
cell = grid.get_cell(n)
cell.fluid_type = FluidType.OIL
cell.fluid_volume = 50

# 2. Spawn Conductive Water Basins
for center in floor_positions[3:6]:
for n in [center] + center.neighbors_4():
if grid.in_bounds(n) and grid.get_cell(n).tile == TileType.FLOOR:
cell = grid.get_cell(n)
cell.fluid_type = FluidType.WATER
cell.fluid_volume = 60

# 3. Spawn Explosive Barrels near tactical bottlenecks
for b_pos in floor_positions[6:10]:
barrel = ecs.create_entity(name="Explosive Barrel", tags={"explosive", "container"})
ecs.add_component(barrel.id, Position(b_pos))
ecs.add_component(barrel.id, Renderable(glyph="O", color="red", name="Explosive Barrel",
render_order=5))
ecs.add_component(barrel.id, Physics(weight=25.0, fragile=True, explosive=True, explosion_radius=2,
explosion_damage=40))
ecs.add_component(barrel.id, Flammable(fuel=15, ignition_temp=120))
grid.add_item(barrel.id, b_pos)
```

Placing these features creates dynamic battlegrounds where every room offers distinct tactical opportunities (e.g. electrocuting water puddles, igniting oil slicks, or luring enemies toward explosive barrels).

Chapter 12: Procedural Encounters, Synergies & Bounded Chaos

"A procedural encounter should not simply be five goblins waiting in a room. It should be a dynamic scenario mid-motion—a predator stalking prey, or rival factions disputing territory over an environmental hazard."

12.1 Threat Budgets & Hazard Budgets

In traditional RPG encounter design, a room's difficulty is calculated purely by summing monster Combat Ratings ($\sum \text{CR}$).

In a systemic roguelike, this formula is fatally flawed: a room containing two weak goblins is trivial on flat dry ground, but lethal if the floor is an electrified acid pool surrounded by poison vents.

We model encounter difficulty using a **Dual-Budget System**:

$$\text{Total Challenge} = w_m \cdot \text{Threat Budget} + w_h \cdot \text{Hazard Budget}$$

MERMAID

```
graph TD
LevelTarget["Dungeon Floor Target Budget: 100 pts"] --> Split{Budget Split}
Split --> Threat["Monster Threat Budget: 60 pts"]
Split --> Hazard["Environmental Hazard Budget: 40 pts"]

Threat --> Monsters["Spawn: 1 Goblin Shaman (40 pts) + 2 Grunts (20 pts)"]
Hazard --> Terrain["Spawn: 1 Acid Pool (25 pts) + 1 Gas Vent (15 pts)"]
```

When the ProcGen algorithm allocates high environmental hazard density to a sector, it automatically dials back monster spawns, preventing unfair, unwinnable death traps.

12.2 Synergistic and Antagonistic Encounter Pairs

To spark emergent battles, the encounter generator intentionally spawns **synergistic pairs** and **antagonistic factions**:

1. Synergistic Encounter Pairs (High Threat)

- **Oil Slug + Fire Imp**: The oil slug coats the battlefield and player in flammable oil; the fire imp casts ignition sparks.
- **Frost Witch + Water Golem**: The water golem douses actors in water; the frost witch freezes the puddle, trapping the player in solid ice.

2. Antagonistic Encounters (Tactical Opportunities)

- **Wolf Pack + Goblin Guard**: Spawned adjacent to each other. When the player approaches, the two groups are already locked in combat, allowing the player to choose whether to intervene, sneak past, or exploit the

distraction.

12.3 Deterministic Seeding and Isolated RNG Streams

A critical architectural pitfall in procedural games is relying on a single global pseudo-random number generator (such as Python's default **`random`**).

The Butterfly Effect Bug

If a single monster takes an extra combat swing on Turn 3, it consumes an extra random number from the global stream. This alters the RNG state, causing Dungeon Floor 2 to generate with a completely different map layout!

Channel-Partitioned RNG Architecture

To maintain strict determinism, we partition the random number generator into **isolated subsystem streams**:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
MasterSeed["Master Seed (e.g. 1337)"] --> RNGManager
RNGManager --> StreamGen["RNGChannel.WORLD_GEN"]
RNGManager --> StreamCombat["RNGChannel.COMBAT"]
RNGManager --> StreamAI["RNGChannel.AI"]
RNGManager --> StreamCellular["RNGChannel.CELLULAR"]
RNGManager --> StreamLoot["RNGChannel.LOOT"]
```

PYTHON

```
class RNGChannel(Enum):
WORLD_GEN = auto()
COMBAT = auto()
AI = auto()
CELLULAR = auto()
LOOT = auto()

class RNGManager:
def __init__(self, master_seed: int = 1337) -> None:
self.reseed(master_seed)

def reseed(self, master_seed: int) -> None:
self.master_seed = master_seed
master_rng = random.Random(master_seed)
self._streams = {}
for channel in RNGChannel:
sub_seed = master_rng.randint(0, 2**31 - 1)
self._streams[channel] = random.Random(sub_seed)

def get(self, channel: RNGChannel) -> random.Random:
return self._streams[channel]
```

With isolated streams:

- Player combat actions consume numbers exclusively from **`RNGChannel.COMBAT`**.
- Next-level floor generation reads exclusively from **`RNGChannel.WORLD_GEN`**, guaranteeing that identical world seeds generate identical dungeon layouts regardless of player combat turns.

Chapter 13: Determinism, State Serialization & Replays

> *"If a simulation cannot be serialized to disk and replayed deterministically from an input log, it cannot be debugged at scale."*

13.1 Pure State vs. Side Effects

In an emergent roguelike containing hundreds of simultaneous interactions, reproducing complex bugs requires **deterministic simulation**.

To achieve strict determinism:

1. **No External Clock Calls in Core Logic**: Never call `time.time()` or `datetime.now()` to compute cooldowns or decay. All time is measured in discrete **Simulation Ticks**.
2. **No Unseeded Random Calls**: Direct calls to `random.random()` or global system entropy are forbidden; all randomness flows through partitioned `RNGManager` channels.
3. **Deterministic Iteration Order**: Avoid iterating over native Python `set` or `dict` objects where hash seed randomization can alter execution order across process restarts. Order entities by monotonic integer `id`.

MERMAID

```
graph LR
MasterSeed[Initial Master Seed] --> Sim[Simulation Engine]
InputLog["Input Stream (Turn 1..N)"] --> Sim
Sim --> StateSnapshot["Deterministic Final State Hash (SHA-256)"]
```

13.2 State Serialization and Save-Game Schema

Because components in our ECS are pure Python dataclasses, serializing the entire world state into JSON or binary formats is straightforward:

PYTHON

```
import json
from typing import Any

def serialize_world(grid: LayeredGrid, ecs: EntityManager, scheduler: EnergyScheduler) -> str:
state = {
"version": 1,
"scheduler_tick": scheduler.current_tick,
"grid": {
"width": grid.width,
"height": grid.height,
"cells": [
{
"tile": cell.tile.name,
"fluid": cell.fluid_type.name,
"fluid_vol": cell.fluid_volume,
"gas": cell.gas_type.name,
"gas_dens": cell.gas_density,
"fire": cell.fire_intensity,
"temp": cell.temperature,
"actor": cell.actor,
"items": cell.items,
}
for cell in grid._cells
]
},
"entities": [
{
"id": entity.id,
"name": entity.name,
"tags": list(entity.tags),
# Serialize attached components
}
for entity in ecs._entities.values()
]
}
return json.dumps(state, indent=2)
```

13.3 Headless Monte Carlo Simulation Testing

How do you verify that a complex combination of fire, fluids, monsters, and spells will not trigger an infinite loop or crash after 50,000 turns?

We construct **Headless Monte Carlo Bots** that run simulations at maximum CPU speed without graphics:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
Spawn[Spawn Procedural Level] --> BotLoop[Headless AI Bot Loop]
BotLoop --> MakeMove[Select Random / Utility Action]
MakeMove --> StepSim[Step Cellular & Event Systems]
StepSim --> CheckInvariants{Assert Invariants}

CheckInvariants -->|Violation / Crash| LogBug[Dump Seed & Replay Log]
CheckInvariants -->|Turn Count Reached| NextSeed[Test Next Seed]
```

Invariant Assertions to Monitor

- **Conservation of Mass/Fluid**: Fluid volume in a sealed room cannot spontaneously increase without an emitter component.
- **Bounded Maximum Temperature**: No cell may exceed 2000°C (guards against runaway thermal loops).
- **Recursion Depth Bounding**: Event bus cascade depth must never exceed `MAX_CASCADE_DEPTH`.
- **Zero Orphaned Pointers**: No grid cell may reference an actor ID that has been destroyed in the `EntityManager`.

Running headless bots across thousands of procedural seeds in continuous integration (CI) surfaces obscure edge cases before players ever encounter them.

Chapter 14: Balancing Emergent Systems

"Given the opportunity, players will optimize the fun out of a game. Therefore, the designer's job is to protect the player from themselves." — Soren Johnson & Sid Meier

---

14.1 The Combinatorial Balancing Dilemma

In a linear RPG, balancing an encounter is a spreadsheet exercise: adjust Monster HP until average Player Damage per Second requires 4 hits to kill.

In an emergent roguelike, this direct approach collapses:

- If a player uses basic melee, the monster takes 4 hits.
- If a player coats the monster in oil, freezes it, shocks the puddle, and drops a boulder on its head, the monster takes 600 damage in 1 turn.

If you balance monster HP around the basic melee attack, clever systemic play instantly trivializes the entire game. If you balance monster HP around the 600-damage combo, basic melee becomes impossible.

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Balancing Levers
SoftCaps["1. Soft Caps & Diminishing Returns"]
Entropy["2. Environmental Entropy & Dissipation"]
Scarcity["3. Reagent Scarcity & Opportunity Cost"]
Symmetry["4. Symmetrical Threat: Hazards Threaten Player Too"]
end
```

14.2 Mathematical Levers: Diminishing Returns & Soft Caps

To prevent compounding multipliers from blowing up to infinity, we utilize **Asymptotic Soft Caps**:

$$\text{Effective Damage} = D_{\text{base}} \times \left(1 + \frac{M_{\text{compound}}}{1 + \frac{M_{\text{compound}}}{K}}\right)$$

Where K is the soft-cap threshold (e.g. $K = 3.0$).

PYTHON

```python
def calculate_compounded_damage(base_damage: float, multipliers: list[float], soft_cap: float = 3.0)
-> float:
total_mult = 1.0
for m in multipliers:
total_mult *= m

if total_mult > soft_cap:
# Asymptotic compression above soft cap
total_mult = soft_cap + (total_mult - soft_cap) ** 0.5

return base_damage * total_mult
```

This ensures that clever combinations remain satisfyingly rewarding without breaking the mathematical boundaries of the game.

14.3 Environmental Entropy and Decay Timers

Unchecked systemic simulations naturally trend toward infinite chaos unless governed by **Entropy and Conservation Laws**:

1. **Combustion Fuel Caps**: Every fire tile consumes 1 unit of **`fire_fuel`** per tick. Without fresh fuel (oil, wood), fire extinguishes automatically within 5–10 turns.
2. **Gas Dissipation Rates**: Gas clouds lose $\Delta d = 2$ density per turn to ambient atmospheric absorption.
3. **Thermal Relaxation**: Ambient tiles passively decay back toward room temperature (20°C) at a steady rate of 5°C per tick.

MERMAID

```
graph LR
EnergySpike[Spike: Fire / Heat / Gas] --> Peak[Peak Interaction]
Peak -->|Entropy Decay| Ambient[Return to Ambient Equilibrium (20°C)]
```

Entropy guarantees that catastrophic battles leave scars on the dungeon (scorched walls, shattered doors, puddles of water), but restore thermodynamic stability for subsequent exploration.

14.4 Symmetrical Vulnerability

The ultimate balancing equalizer in traditional roguelikes is **Symmetry**:

> ***Rule of Symmetry**: Any systemic trick the player can inflict on the dungeon, the dungeon can inflict on the player.*

- If water conducts electricity for 30 damage, the player standing in a water puddle is equally vulnerable to an electric shock.
- If dense smoke blinds goblins, it blinds the player too.
- If explosive barrels deal 40 damage, an enemy archer shooting a fire arrow at a barrel next to the player is lethal.

Symmetry transforms powerful emergent mechanics from brainless "win buttons" into intense high-risk, high-reward tactical decisions.

Chapter 15: Reference Engine Deep Dive & Extension Guide

"A well-architected engine is not one where everything is written, but one where new systems can be added without modifying existing code."

15.1 Architecture Overview of `pyrogue-emergent`

Throughout this book, we have designed and built a modular reference engine: **`pyrogue-emergent`**. Below is the complete dependency and communication flow:

MERMAID

```
graph TD
subgraph Core Architecture
Scheduler[EnergyScheduler]
EventBus[Multi-Phase EventBus]
RNG[RNGManager Streams]
end

subgraph Spatial Simulation
Grid[LayeredGrid]
CA[CellularSimulator: Fire/Fluid/Gas/Temp]
FOV[SymmetricShadowcasting]
end

subgraph Entity & Mechanics
ECS[EntityManager]
Affordance[AffordanceSystem]
Status[StatusEffectSystem]
Alchemy[AlchemySystem]
end

subgraph Autonomous Intelligence
Dijkstra[DijkstraMap]
Utility[UtilityAI]
Ecology[FactionSystem]
end

subgraph Procedural Generation
ProcGen[CellularCaveGenerator]
Tactical[TacticalFeaturePlacer]
Populator[EcosystemPopulator]
end

Scheduler --> EventBus
EventBus --> Affordance
Affordance --> Grid
Affordance --> ECS
Affordance --> Status
Affordance --> CA
Utility --> Dijkstra
Utility --> Affordance
```

15.2 Step-by-Step Extension Guides

Let us demonstrate the extensibility of this architecture by adding three common roguelike features.

Recipe 1: Adding a New Elemental Medium — *Cryogenic Frostfire*

Suppose we want to add *Frostfire*: a mystical flame that freezes matter instead of heating it, and solidifies water into blue ice while emitting freezing fog.

1. **Add Enum & Component**:

```python
# In grid.py: Add to GasType
class GasType(Enum):
...
FREEZING_FOG = auto()
```

2. **Add Cellular Rule in `cellular.py`**:

```python
# In CellularSimulator.step():
if curr.gas_type == GasType.FREEZING_FOG and curr.gas_density > 20:
nxt.temperature = max(-50, nxt.temperature - 15)
if nxt.fluid_type == FluidType.WATER:
nxt.tile = TileType.ICE
nxt.fluid_type = FluidType.NONE
logs.append(f"Freezing fog solidified water into ice at ({pos.x}, {pos.y})!")
```

3. **No other files need to be touched!** All existing items, creatures, and spells that interact with temperature and ice automatically work with Frostfire.

Recipe 2: Adding a New Affordance Verb — `Magnetize`

Suppose we want a spell or wand that magnetizes entities, causing all metallic items and iron-armored creatures to be pulled toward each other.

1. **Add Handler in `affordances.py`**:

```python
def _handle_magnetize(self, event: ActionEvent) -> None:
origin = event.target_pos
radius = event.data.get("magnetic_radius", 5)

for entity, (pos, material) in self.ecs.query(Position, Material):
if material.material_type == MaterialType.IRON:
dist = origin.chebyshev_dist(pos.pos)
if 0 < dist <= radius:
step = pos.pos.step_towards(origin)
self.grid.move_actor(entity.id, pos.pos, step)
event.message += f" Iron entity {entity.id} yanked by magnetic force!"
```

2. Any entity made of **`MaterialType.IRON`** (swords, shields, iron golems, bear traps) will now physically fly across the room toward the magnetic pole.

15.3 The Emergent Designer's Manifesto

As you embark on building your own traditional roguelike or systemic simulation, keep these core principles at the center of your engineering:

1. **Never Hardcode Nouns**: Treat everything as composable properties, materials, and tags.
2. **Simulate Matter, Not Magic**: Magic should feel like an extreme, reality-bending application of physics and chemistry.
3. **Preserve Determinism**: Seed your RNG streams cleanly; test with headless Monte Carlo bots.
4. **Legibility Over Chaos**: Give players the perceptual tools to predict, plan, and understand the beautiful chain reactions they ignite.

May your dungeons be deep, your oil slicks flammable, and your simulations richly alive.